

Why some interpretable deviations count as ungrammatical: linguistic norms and levels of explanation

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Abstract

I develop an account of why some readily interpretable deviations count as ungrammatical while others count as lexical, phonological, orthographic, stylistic, pragmatic, or social. The account treats a grammatical norm as a socially sustained relation that governs how recurrent linguistic expressions are formed, and a grammatical fault as a performance's failure to conform to such a relation. It distinguishes that norm and failure from their consequences for meaning and interaction, from what speakers treat as wrong, from what causes those responses, and from the evidence available to analysts. I apply the account to French article elision, English inflection and complementation, register and honorific choice, and switch-reference. The analysis separates failures of expression formation from recoverable meanings, unintended messages, pronunciation, spelling, and downstream judgments or sanctions. It predicts that relations identified independently as part of grammatical expression formation will attract more consistent formation-directed attribution than matched neighbouring faults. It also predicts that, among grammatical paradigms, contrasts with stronger consequences for discourse organization will produce larger differences between discourse-directed and form-directed repair. These predictions test whether the analysis extends beyond the cases used to construct it; they don't define grammatical status.

Keywords: grammaticality; linguistic norm; linguistic assembly; target attribution; semantic repair; discourse consequence

AI USE. The large language models Claude Opus 4.5 and Claude Fable 5; a preview model with no disclosed developer or underlying-model identity, accessed through OpenCode Zen in August 2026; ChatGPT 5.2 Pro; and GPT-5.5 served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

Beyond copy-editing, these systems assisted with literature triage, adversarial review, argument development, and drafting. I checked the cited sources and adjudicated their suggestions; no language model is an author.

I THE SELECTIVE-CLASSIFICATION PROBLEM

In contemporary French, *hiver* ‘winter’ begins with H MUET (Office québécois de la langue française, 2021), and the singular definite article undergoes elision: *l’hiver*, not **le hiver* (Boersma, 2007, pp. 1990–1991, 1994), with the asterisk marking the latter as ungrammatical. The deviant form remains easy to understand. Simonenko and Carlier (2020, pp. 395–398) treat the modern French *l*-forms as definite determiners; *le* still presents the noun phrase as masculine, singular, and definite. The problem lies in how that article is realized before this class of noun. The deviation is neither a wrong referent nor a failure to communicate definiteness. It also needn’t be treated as a general phonological defect of French. The disputed relation belongs to the realization of the article construction.

The transparency of this deviant form raises a general question. Why do some interpretable departures count as ungrammatical while others count as semantic anomaly, poor wording, pronunciation, spelling, style, or social conduct? Meaninglessness can’t supply the distinction: **le hiver*, **goed*, and many agreement errors are transparent. Expressive substance can’t mark it either. Segments, words, word order, prosody, gesture, and writing can realize grammatical contrasts, while the same resources can distinguish words, accents, and styles. An asterisk is a useful mark but a poor theory. It records a classification without explaining it (compare Coseriu, 2019, p. 37). I use it here for forms conventionally treated as deviant, without prejudging which kind of relation has failed.

The relevant literature establishes several parts of the puzzle. Coseriu (2019, pp. 32–39, 98–101) separates correctness relative to a historical language from congruence and appropriateness, and a failure of correctness from the judgment of it. Acceptability work shows that a negative judgment doesn’t reveal whether grammar, processing, interpretation, or contextualization caused it (Hofmeister et al., 2013; Leivada & Westergaard, 2020). Semantic work explains why some anomalous combinations remain interpretable (Abrusán, 2019; Abrusán et al., 2021). Work on grammatical paradigms and interaction shows how conventional choices can organize both expression and uptake (Fox et al., 1996; Nørgård-Sørensen & Heltoft, 2015). Together these results sharpen a classificatory and constitutive question: what makes the failed relation grammatical in the first place, and how can that status be distinguished from people’s fallible reactions to it?

My central claim is:

Constitutive claim. A grammatical fault is a failure in a socially sustained relation used to assemble recurrent linguistic expressions.

In **le hiver*, the intended noun phrase and its definiteness remain identifiable, but the article doesn’t have the realization required in that environment. A poor lexical choice, a misspelling, and an inappropriate register can also violate conventions, but they disrupt different relations. The distinction is contribution-based: it concerns what the convention governs, not whether the departure is noticeable or important, or whether the relevant contrast is realized in segments, words, word order, prosody, gesture, or writing.

The constitutive claim becomes clearer when six questions are kept apart. The French example illustrates all six:

- (1) NORM CONSTITUTION: what makes the article-realization relation a grammatical norm rather than a general phonological constraint of French?

- (2) TOKEN APPLICATION: does **le hiver* fail that relation while preserving the other relations needed to identify the noun phrase?
- (3) SEMANTIC OR PRAGMATIC CONSEQUENCE: what remains interpretable, and what effect does the failure have on reference, force, or uptake?
- (4) TARGET ATTRIBUTION: does a respondent identify the trouble as article formation, pronunciation, spelling, foreignness, or something else?
- (5) RESPONSE CAUSATION: did that response arise from linguistic knowledge, processing difficulty, schooling, stigma, or the task itself?
- (6) EPISTEMIC JUSTIFICATION: what evidence warrants the analyst's answers to the preceding questions?

The last two questions concern the same judgment or repair, but they ask different things about it: what the response points to and why the response occurred. And so the six questions concern five kinds of object rather than six.

Norm constitution comes first. Within a specified linguistic repertoire, a grammatical norm is a socially sustained relation among constructional units, exponents, positions, or values in a recurrent construction. In a broad extension of Saussure's relational notion of VALUE, I use the term for a conventional semantic, structural, relational, or discourse-organizing alternative (for example, past, plural, interrogative, or same-subject) selected or realized within a constructional domain (de Saussure, 1916, Part II, Ch. IV). A grammatical norm supplies a standard for whether a performance conforms to the relevant constructional relation.

The adjective GRAMMATICAL is easily equivocal here. A relation can be *grammatical* in the classificatory sense that it belongs to grammar, whereas a performance can be *grammatically conforming* or *grammatically defective* relative to that relation. I use the bare adjective for the first sense only where the object is plainly a relation or norm; for performances, conformity language keeps the two senses apart.

Other linguistic norms govern other jobs. A lexical convention establishes the identity and content of a sign. A phonotactic convention constrains how phonological elements may be combined. Orthography represents linguistic expressions in writing. A usage norm governs whether an otherwise licensed expression or persona fits an occasion. These can overlap in one performance, but they shouldn't be collapsed merely because all are conventional or socially consequential.

The constitutive claim is relative to a REPERTOIRE: the conventional resources sustained by a particular community in an activity, medium, and period. Reference French conversation, formal written French, and an English-speaking learner classroom needn't sustain exactly the same relations. These dimensions define the scope of a claim about grammatical status. Researchers may refine that scope using evidence about who interacts with whom, what forms are produced and understood, and where and when the forms occur. But the scope has to be fixed before examining the judgments or repairs that the analysis aims to predict. If two independently reasonable scopes yield different results, the broader repertoire may genuinely contain competing norms; selecting whichever population restores the preferred verdict would hide that fact.

AN ASSEMBLY PROFILE organizes the analyst's evidence about a proposed norm. It records whether a form and value are coupled at a constructional site, how the alternatives are organized, and where the relation is licensed. Evidence can come from production, interpretation, substitution, omission, productivity, and distribution. The category descriptions needed to state the relation

(such as *definite*, *singular*, *determiner*, and *vowel-initial noun*) aren't excluded. What's withheld is the prior verdict that the relation or performance is grammatical, together with corrections and repairs that express such a verdict, because those responses are later used to test whether speakers identify the same relation. The profile can be uncertain or wrong; it represents the proposed norm rather than constituting it.

With category descriptions allowed but status verdicts and later responses withheld, the primary prediction is that relations identified as grammatical assembly norms should more consistently prompt speakers to say that expression formation went wrong than matched lexical, phonotactic, graphic, or deployment faults. Explicit use of the word "grammar" is a further outcome and may depend heavily on schooling. A separate application concerns discourse: among independently identified grammatical paradigms, stronger effects on move type, commitment, reference continuity, or response possibilities should produce a larger difference between discourse-directed and form-directed repair.

The six questions organize the paper. Section 2 explains why they require different kinds of answer. Section 3 addresses norm constitution, and Section 4 addresses token application. Section 5 concerns semantic and pragmatic consequences. Section 6 uses difficult examples to test the proposed norm and fault classifications. Section 7 returns to target attribution, response causation, and epistemic justification by asking how the account could be tested or shown to fail.

2 FIVE LEVELS, SIX EXPLANATORY QUESTIONS

The word "grammaticality" is used for objects at several explanatory levels. Here "level" marks a difference in what's being explained, not a hierarchy in which one object is more fundamental than another. A community sustains a linguistic norm; a performance conforms or fails to conform; an interpreted utterance or communicative act has semantic or pragmatic consequences; a speaker or institution responds; and an analyst uses corpora, elicitation, formal models, and recorded ratings as evidence. These claims aren't interchangeable. A formal grammar may fail to generate a community-licensed form because the model undergenerates. A speaker may reject a licensed form because it belongs to an unfamiliar dialect. And an experimenter may record a low rating caused by processing difficulty rather than by any grammatical fault. Treating all three outcomes as measurements of one latent yes-no grammaticality property hides the dependencies that need explanation. Table 1 separates the five kinds of object introduced above.

For **le hiver*, the norm organization is the proposed relation between the singular definite article and its realization before this class of noun. Token status concerns whether this particular performance conforms to that relation. The semantic consequence is limited because definiteness and reference remain recoverable. A correction such as "Say *l'hiver*" is a public response, and its wording may target article formation, pronunciation, or learner identity. Corpus distribution, substitution contrasts, elicitation, and that response all provide epistemic access, but none is identical to the relation itself.

These levels are connected, but they don't form a single causal sequence. A norm supplies the standard relative to which token status is assessed. The form and value relations in a performance can affect interpretation and response; whether the performance is called grammatical or ungrammatical doesn't itself produce those effects. Processing difficulties, mishearing, task demands, schooling, stigma, and institutional authority can also affect response without altering the performance's gram-

Level	Object	Question
Norm organization	a recurrent form–value relation in a scoped repertoire	what makes the relation grammatical rather than lexical, phonological, graphic, stylistic, or social?
Token status	a performance analyzed relative to that relation	which relation, if any, does the performance fail to conform to?
Semantic or pragmatic consequence	the interpreted utterance or communicative act	what happens to composition, reference, force, commitment, continuity, or response possibilities?
Public response	a judgment, correction, repair, accommodation, or sanction	what did this person or institution target? What caused that response?
Epistemic access	corpora, elicitation, substitutions, judgments, repairs, and models	what warrants the analyst’s claims about the other levels?

Table 1: Levels that a theory of selective grammaticality has to keep distinct.

matical status. A teacher may correctly identify the article error because training makes them attend to it. What the correction targets doesn’t reveal what caused it, and what caused it doesn’t determine whether the target is correct. Over longer periods, production, accommodation, correction, and sanction can help maintain or change the repertoire. That historical feedback doesn’t make a particular response the truth-maker of the norm to which it reacts.

Figure 1 summarizes these dependencies without turning them into a single sequence.

Dependency	Kind of relation
Norm organization → conformity or defect of the performance	constitutive
The performance’s linguistic organization → semantic or pragmatic consequences	semantic or pragmatic
The performance, its consequences, and the situation → public response	causal
Processing, task, schooling, stigma, and authority → public response	additional causal
Across time: recurrent production, accommodation, correction, and sanction → maintenance or change of norm organization	diachronic feedback

Corpora, elicitation, formal analyses, judgments, and repairs provide fallible evidence about these dependencies; they aren’t additional stages in a single process.

Figure 1: The explanatory levels don’t form a pipeline from norm to judgment. One constitutive dependency fixes conformity, linguistic organization bears on interpretation, two causal routes converge on public response, and recurrent practice can feed back into norm organization over historical time.

Practice sustains the norm; the norm supplies the standard; the performance conforms to or fails that standard. Semantic consequence and public response involve additional dependencies.

Each question also calls for a different kind of explanation. A CONSTITUTIVE EXPLANATION says what makes a relation a grammatical norm and what makes a token defective relative to it. A FUNCTIONAL EXPLANATION says what work the relation does in assembling expressions or organizing discourse. A semantic or pragmatic explanation says why an attempted combination is coherent, anomalous, repairable, or consequential.

The account developed below uses a contribution-based distinction within its constitutive answer. Asking what a relation contributes helps classify the norm; explaining what a particular grammatical choice does in composition or discourse remains a separate functional question.

An attributional explanation identifies which relation a public response treats as failed. A causal explanation says why a particular person reacted. An epistemic justification says why an analyst should believe any of these claims. These are the six questions in explanatory form. More specifically, successful prediction of held-out fault attributions from an independently specified norm analysis can strengthen the epistemic justification for that analysis. But a black-box classifier of the word *grammar* wouldn't thereby explain what makes the classified relation grammatical.

The source-ambiguity literature establishes the need for this separation at the response level. Hofmeister et al. (2013, pp. 48–49) show that a low acceptability rating doesn't identify whether grammar, processing, interpretation, or contextualization caused it. Leivada and Westergaard (2020, pp. 1–4) likewise document dissociations between acceptability and grammaticality. These are constraints on the use of judgments as evidence. They don't by themselves determine which worldly relation a respondent is trying to classify.

Coseriu (2019, pp. 98–101) had already separated a failure of correctness from the judgment of it. A hearer, he argues, issues a judgment of incorrectness only when a deficiency of knowledge is presumed. A native speaker who says *estirar la pata* 'kick the bucket' where the style calls for *morir* 'die' is presumed to know better and is judged inappropriate; a foreigner who uses the idiom is told it's incorrect. So whether a judgment of incorrectness is issued depends on what the respondent assumes about the speaker as well as on the relation the performance fails.

The distinction between object and evidence also applies to formal and descriptive grammars. A formal theory can undergenerate a community-licensed pattern or generate one that speakers in the specified repertoire don't sustain. Conversely, a descriptive grammar may record a robust relation without explaining why it's grammatical rather than governed by a different norm. This is why descriptive evidence has to enter as evidence for a proposed relation, rather than as an inherited status verdict. In a compatible methodological argument, Poulsen (2012, pp. 16–17) treats corpus distributions, processing measures, and judgments as indirect evidence for relatively stable conventional knowledge. The linguistic object, its representation, and the evidence for it remain separate even when a good theory brings them into alignment. Section 3 now turns from this map of explanatory questions to the first and most basic one: what constitutes a grammatical norm.

3 WHAT MAKES A NORM GRAMMATICAL?

As a representational starting point, I use a broad semiotic inventory but individuate norms by what they govern. Goldberg (1995, pp. 1–7) places words, idioms, partly filled patterns, and abstract constructions in a broad inventory of conventional form–meaning pairings. Sag (2012, pp. 69–71, 104–106) develops a related sign-based architecture while distinguishing listemes from constructions more carefully. I adopt that representational choice, but it doesn't by itself classify the relations inside the inventory. Because words and schematic patterns are constructions on the same continuum, Construction Grammar makes the present question sharper rather than making it disappear: which relations within that inventory belong to grammar, and why? The assembly-norm account adds a functional criterion for that purpose; it doesn't depend on Construction Grammar having overlooked or denied the grammar–lexicon question.

3.1 PRACTICE-DEPENDENT, RESPONSE-INDEPENDENT STANDARDS

The answer has two parts. Coordinated practice supplies the standard of correctness; participation in recurrent constructional assembly makes that standard grammatical.

A linguistic norm is more than a frequent event type. It supplies a standard against which novel or disputed tokens can conform or fail to conform. Low-token- frequency constructions can be securely licensed, while frequent innovations can remain restricted or unstable. A norm needn't be explicitly represented as a rule, prescribed by an institution, morally obligatory, or identically stored by every speaker. It's socially sustained when production and interpretation converge on a relation, participants rely on it in forming and understanding new tokens, and counterfactual substitutions or omissions make systematic differences within a scoped repertoire.

Coseriu (1952, pp. 166–168) supplies a precedent. His distinction among system, norm, and speech separates functional possibilities, customary social realization, and concrete linguistic activity. His lectures on correctness separate congruence with thought and knowledge of things, correctness relative to a historical language, and appropriateness to a discourse (Coseriu, 2019, pp. 32–39, 60–61). This account inherits those distinctions, and other sections draw on his treatments of innovation, liaison, incongruence, and suspended judgment. It adds a question that Coseriu sets aside. He treats lexical propriety as a form of the idiomatic correctness that also covers grammar and phonology (Coseriu, 2019, p. 39), so his distinctions don't say which contribution to expression formation makes a norm grammatical.

The paper explicates public repertoire status for conventional linguistic classification and descriptive grammar. Other legitimate targets for “grammaticality” remain. Psycholinguistic accounts can model individual competence and innovations not yet sustained more widely. A formal grammar can model an idiolect or a public variety. In each case, derivability establishes status relative to that model and target; it doesn't by itself establish public licensing. Conversely, speakers can reliably follow a public relation without consciously representing, correcting, or institutionally enforcing it.

I treat individual, model-relative, and public claims as distinct targets that can inform one another without serving as proxies for one another. Earlier distinctions between stable grammatical knowledge, performance, and judgment support the need for this separation (Poulsen, 2012, pp. 4–6, 16–17; Leivada and Westergaard, 2020, pp. 1–6); the three-way division developed here is more specific.

Coseriu (2019, pp. 95–96) likewise assigns well-formedness to the language as a system and correctness to its realization in discourse. The perfective progressive *estuve hablando* ‘I was speaking (for a bounded period)’ is well formed, but it's incorrect where the intended content calls for the imperfective *estaba hablando*. He wouldn't grant the idiolect target, because correctness requires comparison with an intersubjective language (Coseriu, 2019, p. 98). Here idiolect-relative status is a different target, not an empty one.

The first question, norm constitution, receives a functional answer. A grammatical norm relates independently supported constructional units, exponents, positions, or values within a recurrent construction. The relevant constructional relations needn't all occur at the same grain or within constructions of the same size. In subject–verb agreement, the subject noun phrase supplies a number value and the finite-clause construction provides the verb position whose form covaries with it. In French article elision, the definite noun phrase construction relates a selected determiner value to its realization before a particular class of nominal. In complementation, a head–complement construc-

tion relates a head, a complement function, and the phrase that realizes that function. These relations differ in generality, but each helps determine how linguistic material is assembled as an instance of a recurrent construction.

“Assembly” here names a functional relation, not a claim that speakers mechanically join a sequence of pre-existing pieces.¹ An assembly relation can hold simultaneously across a construction, be expressed prosodically or gesturally, or have no overt exponent. In Construction Grammar terms, it’s a relation within or among constructions; the added claim is that some such relations help determine grammatical conformity while others establish lexical identity or govern use. The term says only that the relation helps determine whether a performance conforms to a recurrent expression type.

Other conventions govern different aspects of the same performance. A lexical convention establishes that *winter* is a word with a particular content. English phonotactics constrains the possible phonological form of that word. Orthography specifies its written representation. A register convention can make the word or construction more appropriate in one activity than another. Words, phonological units in spoken or signed languages, and social meanings can participate in grammatical assembly, but merely being conventional or meaningful doesn’t make a relation grammatical. The question is whether the relation organizes how independently identifiable linguistic resources combine or realize a constructional value.

The English double-copula pattern in *The thing is, is that we left early* illustrates the difference between recognizability and grammatical analysis. The sequence is readily understood, and it recurs in conditioned spontaneous-speech environments (Coppock & Staum, 2004, §§ 2.3 and 3.1). Those facts make it a candidate construction rather than random repetition. Its grammatical status depends on whether the two copulas occupy independently supported positions in a recurrent construction, not simply on the fact that speakers understand it or that editors dislike it. The same reasoning applies to the disputed examples throughout this paper.

Defective performances require three objects to remain distinct. First comes the utterance or inscription itself. Second comes its recoverable affiliation with a construction: listeners can recognize **le hiver* as an attempted definite noun phrase. Third comes its conformity or defect relative to each relation in that construction. The noun, definiteness, gender, and number can be preserved even when article realization fails. The relations it preserves keep the performance recognizable as an instance of the broader construction despite the realization fault. Coseriu (2019, pp. 25, 97) makes recognition a condition on correction: a teacher can correct *árbol* ‘tree’ only after seeing that the plural *árboles* was intended.

This functional distinction has to be identified without using the response it’s later meant to explain. One useful counterfactual holds the intended words, constructional values, and situation constant while changing the disputed relation. If the change determines whether the material conforms to the recurrent construction, the relation contributes to grammatical assembly. If it changes only phonological form, spelling, lexical fit, or suitability for the occasion, a different norm is at issue. Recurrent social reliance supplies the proposed difference between a norm and an accidental one-off pattern.

Miller (2021, pp. 26–27) provides a near precedent, though not a complete argument. He treats

¹This use of *assembly* isn’t Minimalist *Merge*. Merge is a formal structure-building operation on syntactic objects (Chomsky, 1995, p. 226); assembly here is a theory-neutral relation among independently supported constructional units, positions, values, and realizations. It assumes neither binary set formation nor a derivational procedure.

word instances as governed by community-relative local performance standards, sustained by external social mechanisms while internal mechanisms enable the production of new instances. On Miller's account, the standards are conditions on conforming word instances, not summaries of observed frequencies. Miller leaves their nature open. I draw the further conclusion that stable clustering alone can't supply normativity: a regular distribution becomes a standard only when the linguistic practice relies on it in producing and interpreting further instances.

I call that dependence **CONSTITUTIVE RELIANCE**. Appropriately situated participants are disposed to produce and interpret novel performances through the relation. Their dispositions are sufficiently coordinated to stabilize new instances of the same recurrent constructional organization, and counterfactual substitutions or omissions systematically preserve or disrupt that organization. Corpus distributions, elicitation, and responses provide evidence about this pattern of reliance without constituting it.

The reliance matters normatively because participants use the relation not merely to predict which forms will occur, but to produce and interpret performances as instances of the same constructional type. A departure can convey its intended message while failing a practice-internal condition for a conforming instance. This supplies the thin sense in which the performance is defective relative to the repertoire.

Correctness is thin and practice-internal. A performance is correct or defective relative to a repertoire insofar as it conforms or fails to conform to a standard for constructing or realizing expressions. Pullum (2019, pp. 213–216) similarly argues that grammatical rules define correctness within a linguistic practice without imposing moral, prudential, or instrumental obligations. The further question here is which practice-internal standards are grammatical rather than lexical, phonological, graphic, or social. Institutional approval, actual correction, majority preference, and statistical expectedness don't decide that question. Transmission, teaching, correction, and repair can maintain the norm through time without being part of what sustains it at a given time. A token-level judgment may misidentify the defect, and the absence of correction doesn't remove it (Coseriu, 2019, p. 104). An innovation can be surprising while conforming to an existing construction, whereas a familiar shibboleth can attract condemnation without any assembly failure. Participation in constructional assembly supplies the assembly-norm account's criterion of grammar-specificity: the standard governs relations among signs, exponents, or values in recurrent expression formation. It's a functional explication of grammatical status, not a conclusion forced by recurrence or social coordination alone.

A single performance can conform to one relation, fail a second, and attract sanction under a third. Lexical valence can help determine whether a complement construction is licensed, and item-specific allomorphy can realize a grammatical value. Such performances contain more than one relevant relation. But the analysis can't posit a grammatical relation merely because some respondents call the problem "grammar", or a lexical relation merely because others call it "wording". Sign identity, conventional value, contribution to construction formation, and repertoire scope have to be identified independently of those labels.

Table 2 excludes pure phonotactics from grammar in the target sense. A pure phonotactic norm constrains the well-formedness of a phonological form in the relevant modality independently of any contrast among constructional values. A phonological relation enters grammatical assembly only when conditioned by, or when realizing, a grammatical choice. A restriction on which segments may occur at the beginning of a word, when it holds regardless of grammatical value, concerns possible

Norm type	What the norm governs	Characteristic fault
Grammatical assembly	constructional units, exponents, positions, or values are related within recurrent constructions	a constructional relation, selected value, obligatory contrast, or licensed realization fails
Lexical sign identity and content	a conventional sign has an identity and contributes lexical content	a purported word form realizes no conventional lexeme, violates an independently supported lexical relation, or contributes nonconventional lexical content
Phonological form formation	segments or sign-language parameters, syllable or prosodic structure, and possible word form	expression form fails without a constructional value relation failing
Graphic representation	an independently identified linguistic expression is represented in writing	spelling or graphic convention fails while linguistic assembly remains intact
Usage and social deployment	a licensed expression, repertoire, persona, or act fits an occasion	assembly succeeds but situational or social fit fails
Institutional metalinguistic classification	a school, editor, or prestige institution applies a correctness category	the label can accurately or inaccurately target any preceding relation

Table 2: Functional norm types. The rows can intersect in one token rather than partitioning expressive substances.

word form. By contrast, an English pitch contour can distinguish a statement from a questioning use of the same words (Ladd, 2008, pp. 6–7). In Amele, vowel harmony forms part of the realization of a different-subject switch-reference value (Roberts, 1987, p. 363); in French, elision forms part of the conditioned realization of the singular article. The sounds are grammatically relevant in the latter examples because they realize a constructional choice, not simply because their realizations are phonological.

One performance can contain multiple independently supported relations of different types. The preposition selected by *depend*, for example, can participate both in a complement construction and in lexical knowledge about that head. Japanese polite verb suffixation can organize a recurrent constructional contrast while also indexing persona and relationship (Cook, 2008, pp. 45–64; Ide, 2005, pp. 50–53). A graphic contrast can enter grammar if writers conventionally use it to realize a constructional value, even though most spelling conventions merely represent an expression already identified. These intersections don’t make every linguistic norm grammatical. They show why status belongs to a particular relation as it operates in a repertoire, not to a sound, word, or social meaning considered in isolation.

The criterion identifies the functional role that makes a relation grammatical. The next task is to identify which relation occupies that role and at what grain.

3.2 INDIVIDUATING THE ASSEMBLY RELATION

The preceding subsection said that grammar relates independently supported constructional units, exponents, positions, or values. “Independently supported” doesn’t mean already classified as lexical or grammatical. The point is to avoid inventing a relation solely because a disputed performance has received a grammar label. The analysis proceeds in three stages.

The independence is methodological, not logical or theory-free. Corpus, elicitation, and descriptive evidence can share assumptions, and any segmentation of a performance already reflects an analysis. The requirement is that the evidence used to posit the relation exclude the held-out responses whose targets it predicts, that imported assumptions be stated, and that rival decompositions be compared on the same outcome-blind evidence.

First, the proposed parts need independent support. A sign is supported when its form and contribution recur across combinations. A bound exponent can be identified by its contrast with other

realizations in the same conditioned position. A construction is supported when a distribution and interpretation recur under substitution, omission, or embedding. These patterns identify the possible signs, values, and constructional sites without yet deciding which norm type governs them.

Second, a relational analysis has to explain more than the stored identity of one large expression. Its proposed parts should recur or contrast independently, and varying one should reveal a dependency over an independently motivated position, value, or class. The analysis should also predict behaviour in substitutions, derived forms, or constructional environments not used to posit it. Productivity and structural separability can provide that evidence, but neither is required: an item-restricted construction can still contain a determinate assembly relation.

A whole-sign analysis is favoured when the supposed parts don't preserve their contributions outside the expression and the proposed internal relation predicts nothing beyond an item list. The appropriate unit of analysis is determined by comparison. Competing whole-sign and relational analyses are evaluated by how much independently observed distribution and interpretation they capture without adding a dependency solely for the disputed case. If the evidence supports both analyses equally, the unit of analysis is epistemically indeterminate. If different groups or activities sustain different organizations, the repertoire itself is unsettled at the declared scope. Neither result licenses an automatic verdict of "partly grammatical".

Third, an analysis containing more than one relation has an additional burden. Each proposed relation has to be attested outside the response being explained and make a distinct counterfactual prediction. Inflection inside an idiom, for example, can be separated from the idiom's lexical identity only where the inflectional relation recurs elsewhere and predicts changes within the idiom. Respondents dividing between "grammar" and "wording" isn't enough to establish two relations.

Simple contrasts show what the three stages are meant to distinguish. In **These books is useful*, the words and proposition are recoverable, but the number relation between subject and finite verb fails. In *strong rain*, ordinary adjective–noun modification succeeds, but the lexical combination is unusual compared with *heavy rain*. A nonce form that violates an independently established word-initial phonotactic restriction can fail word formation without disrupting a constructional value. And a Japanese plain-style verb addressed by a young student to a professor can be linguistically well formed while being unsuitable for the relationship. The four performances may all attract negative reactions, but the independently identified relation at issue differs.

English complementation and collocation provide a harder contrast. In *depend on an answer*, the meaning of *depend* introduces a semantic dependency relation. In the clause, a PP realizes the complement function within the VP, and *on* heads that PP. The verb, the complement function, the PP realization, and possible complements of the preposition recur independently. Related forms such as *dependence on* and *dependent on* preserve the head-specific preposition. This supports a set of dependencies connecting semantic relation, syntactic complement function, phrasal category, and an item-restricted choice of preposition.

Not every recurring part of that dependency set is thereby grammatical. Collocations and morphological families also recur across forms. The relevant evidence includes preservation of the semantic relation across different complements, participation in complement alternations, recurrence across derived forms, contrasts with non-complement uses, and whether the preposition realizes a constructional relation rather than merely accompanying a lexical family. The semantic-to-syntactic and complement-to-PP dependencies clearly contribute to grammatical assembly. On the evidence

considered here, the final choice of *on* remains indeterminate between lexically indexed grammatical licensing and lexical collocation – in more traditional terms, between grammar and lexis.

The comparison with *heavy rain* clarifies the distinction. Replacing *heavy* with *strong* can leave the adjective–noun construction grammatical while producing a lexically odd combination. If *depend on* turned out to be stored only as a larger lexical construction whose proposed parts made no independent predictions, the item-specific grammatical analysis would likewise lose support; the final preposition restriction would then be lexical rather than grammatical. The opposite result is also possible. If *heavy* developed into a conventional intensity exponent over an independently supported class of nouns, its selection would become part of grammatical assembly. These conclusions are fixed from distribution and interpretation before corrections or prior grammaticality verdicts are examined.

3.3 PARADIGMS, CONSTRUCTIONAL DEPENDENCIES, AND DISCURSIVE STATUS

Strict paradigms provide a strong case of grammatical assembly. Nørgård-Sørensen and Heltoft (2015, pp. 262–263) characterize a grammatical paradigm through a recurring domain, a language-specific semantic frame, a bounded set of alternatives, obligatory choice in the domain, and marked–unmarked organization. Their account extends beyond inflection to word order and constructional syntax (Nørgård-Sørensen & Heltoft, 2015, pp. 275–285). Hansen and Heltoft (2011, vol. 1, 39–42) likewise allow prototype and radial organization within their account of Danish grammar. These analyses show how a set of values and their realizations can be organized within a repertoire without reducing grammar to segmental morphology.

Paradigmhood doesn't define all grammar under the assembly-norm proposal. Constructional dependencies can be productive without a closed set of values, and item-specific relations can depend on more schematic licensing relations. The assembly-norm account places these relations by asking what they contribute to the formation of constructional tokens. Bounded alternatives, obligatoriness, and markedness are powerful ways of organizing grammatical assembly, not universal conditions on it.

Boye and Harder (2012, p. 1) state their answer directly: “grammar is constituted by expressions that by linguistic convention are ancillary and as such discursively secondary”. On their view, a grammatical expression supports another expression rather than carrying the main point of the utterance. Grammatical meaning is DISCURSIVELY SECONDARY, whereas lexical meaning is capable of becoming primary. Closed paradigms and obligatoriness may correlate with that status, but they don't define it (Boye & Harder, 2012, pp. 30–32).

Boye and Harder (2012, pp. 15–18) diagnose discourse status through focusability and addressability. In *Jones is gonna call her tomorrow*, for example, a reply such as *How?* can ask how Jones will call, but it can't independently question the meaning expressed by *gonna*. Nor does ordinary sentence stress make *gonna* the principal point. A lexical verb such as *call* is more readily focused or questioned. These contrasts support their analysis because they show what can and can't become discourse-primary.

The assembly-norm proposal agrees that substance and frequency don't define grammar, but it treats discourse status differently. Boye and Harder's classification of English demonstratives makes the difference concrete. Boye and Harder (2012, pp. 20–21) classify free-standing *that* as lexical because it can be selectively focused and addressed. The contrast concerns ordinary selective focus, not the mere possibility of prosodic prominence. Boye and Harder exclude explicitly contrastive and

metalinguistic contexts from this diagnostic, so *I want IT, not THEM* isn't a counterexample on their terms. Their claim is that *that* can make its own contribution discourse-primary in ordinary use.

Accepting that discourse diagnosis doesn't settle the status of every relation in which the demonstrative participates. English *this, these, that, and those* form a system crossing proximal–distal deixis with singular–plural number, and demonstrative determinatives function as DETERMINER or fused determiner–head, where one element realizes both functions in the noun phrase (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 373–374, 410–415). Under the assembly criterion, those deictic–number and nominal-construction relations are grammatical even if the demonstrative expression is lexical by Boye and Harder's criterion. The two accounts don't simply assign rival labels to one object: they also disagree about which object should bear grammatical status.

The difference in object matters beyond demonstratives. Boye and Harder classify expressions and meanings by discourse status; the assembly-norm account classifies relations by their role in expression formation. It can accept their observation that *that* can carry the principal point of a performance while denying that this prominence makes every relation in which the demonstrative participates lexical. Conversely, an ancillary parenthetical or discourse marker isn't grammatical merely because it normally remains in the background; it has to participate in an independently supported assembly relation.

This disagreement about the proper object of classification doesn't make Boye and Harder's diagnostics irrelevant. Conventional discourse-secondary status may explain attention, processing, and the behaviour of many familiar grammatical expressions. The constitutive question is whether it can be the sole identity condition for grammar once a discourse-primary expression participates in independently established constructional relations. The comparison has to examine both kinds of evidence without defining either property from the status verdicts to be explained.

Table 3 sets out the resulting contrast among the three proposals.

Account	Constitutive criterion	Difficult case
Strict paradigm account	bounded alternatives in a recurring domain and semantic frame, obligatory selection, and markedness	construction-sized and item-restricted dependencies that lack a strict paradigm
Boye–Harder	conventional ancillarity and discursive secondary status	expressions whose discourse-primary content coexists with independently supported constructional relations
Assembly norm	socially sustained form–value organization internal to recurrent constructional tokens	lexical valence, morphophonology, and social-indexical constructions that serve more than one function

Table 3: Three constitutive proposals. Their diagnostics can supply evidence, but the dispute concerns what grammatical status consists in.

3.4 MULTIPLE RELATIONS AND EPISTEMIC PROFILES

One performance can have different statuses relative to different relations without making evidence, reality, and judgment equally fuzzy. The relations can have different functions – for example, a grammatical complement relation together with a lexically restricted preposition – and different activities can sustain different organizations. Item restriction, low productivity, and narrow distribution don't by themselves make an assembly relation less grammatical. A lexeme-specific relation can determinately belong to grammar if it determinately realizes a grammatical value. Such properties weaken

generality or evidential support only when they also leave the contribution to expression formation uncertain or the relation unsettled across the declared repertoire.

The relation, the profile, and the judgment occupy different roles. The relation is the proposed norm; the profile is the analyst's estimate; the judgment is a response that may or may not track it. The analyst may have strong or weak evidence that the relation exists, and a respondent may apply a categorical or hesitant label. A sharp schoolroom correction doesn't prove a sharply grammatical relation, just as uncertain corpus evidence doesn't prove a fuzzy norm.

More specifically, an ASSEMBLY PROFILE records evidence about whether form and value are coupled at a constructional site, how alternatives and selection are organized, and where the relation is licensed in the declared repertoire. Production, interpretation, substitution, omission, productivity, and opportunity-normalized distribution bear on those questions. A descriptive grammar contributes through the patterns it documents, not by lending the analysis its prior category label.

Adapting Goodman's method of reflective equilibrium (Goodman, 1955, p. 64), Pullum (2017, p. 296) argues that syntactic inquiry should seek coherence among theoretical principles, corpus evidence, and considered judgments: "None of these is to be dismissed – yet crucially, none is sovereign." The profile is compatible with that iterative method, but a held-out test imposes a temporary evidential partition: the particular judgments or repairs to be predicted can't also fix the initial profile. After the test, both the profile and the analysis remain revisable in light of the full evidence.

4 HOW TOKENS FAIL LINGUISTIC NORMS

Sections 3.1 and 3.2 supplied the constitutive criterion and the procedure for individuating a candidate norm. Section 3.4 then separated that norm from the profile used to estimate its organization. Token application, the second of the six questions, begins only after the candidate norm, repertoire, and evidential basis have been specified. It asks which relation, if any, a particular performance fails. The asterisk in **These books is useful* doesn't answer that question. It tells us that someone has classified the example negatively; the analyst still has to locate the conflict between plural subject and singular finite verb (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 84, 237).

An analyst can make a prior epistemic error by applying a norm from the wrong community, activity, medium, or period. That mistake concerns repertoire scope; it isn't a defect in the performance. Once the repertoire is specified, Table 4 lists possible sites of token failure. It's a diagnostic menu, not a sequence through which every performance passes. The entries also separate two senses of "form error". A nonce word can violate ordinary English phonotactics, in which case phonological form is at issue. Or a repertoire can exclude one phonological form as the realization of a grammatical value, as when **goed* uses the productive past exponent where the lexeme-specific realization is *went* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1596–1598, 1607). In the second example, phonological material is the surface of a grammatical realization fault.

Value errors require particular care. Three cases have to remain separate.

1. An INTERNAL VALUE INCOMPATIBILITY arises when linguistic material in the token supplies values that conflict: agreement features disagree, a temporal construction conflicts with an overt temporal specification, or a switch-reference marker conflicts with the subjects supplied by its clause chain. **These books is useful* is straightforward: plural *these books* and singular *is* supply incompatible number instructions. This can be a grammatical failure.
2. In EXTERNAL VALUE MISAPPLICATION, a licensed grammatical value is successfully expressed but

is false, misleading, or inappropriate for the described situation. A yesterday-past form used for an event that actually happened today needn't be ungrammatical. The grammatical tense choice may be false of the situation without conflicting with any other linguistic material.

3. In a MESSAGE-SELECTION ERROR, a speaker chooses a grammatical competitor that doesn't express the intended message. The production is mistaken, but the resulting expression can remain grammatical: saying *She left* when one intended *He left* doesn't make the produced sentence inherently grammatically defective.

Diagnostic	Possible failure	Illustration	Relation at issue
Coverage	the supplied material conforms to no construction sustained in the specified repertoire	recoverable intended question with no conforming constructional form	construction
Compatibility	linguistically supplied instructions conflict	<i>*These books is useful</i>	internal value relation
Saturation	an obligatory contrast or constructional element remains unsupplied	omitted obligatory marker or argument	assembly
Value selection	a constructional competitor conflicts with another linguistically supplied value	same-subject marker with distinct subjects supplied by the clauses	internal value relation
Realization	the intended constructional value is preserved but its exponent or surface form is excluded	<i>*le hiver; *goed</i>	grammatical form
Constructional licensing	a transparent combination is absent from the scoped repertoire	<i>*depend of + OBJ</i>	valence or collocation
Non-assembly fault	linguistic assembly succeeds but content, spelling, persona, situation, or conduct is at issue	register mismatch; misspelling	different norm

Table 4: Diagnostics for token application after repertoire scope has been specified. A single performance can fail more than one relation, and a response can misidentify any of them.

A value can misdescribe the world, miss the speaker's intended message, or conflict with another value supplied by the performance. Of these three cases, only the last establishes a grammatical fault by itself. The distinction follows from the constitutive account: grammaticality concerns conformity to the relations that assemble the linguistic token, not direct correspondence between that token and the world or the speaker's private intention. Semantic and pragmatic theories are needed to explain those further relations. This conclusion concerns token status. What a respondent notices and why they react remain the separate questions of target attribution and response causation.

Selecting an inapposite but licensed word supplies the lexical analogue. The sign keeps its conventional identity and meaning, and the surrounding construction can be well formed; the selected content is simply inapt. A register mismatch can likewise preserve the proposition and the form's conventional social-indexical value while deploying that value in an unsuitable situation. These choices may be serious, accountable, or sharply sanctioned. Their social importance doesn't move the failed relation into grammatical assembly.

Section 5 turns from the location of these faults to the third question: what such conformity or failure does to meaning and interaction.

5 WHAT SEMANTIC AND PRAGMATIC EXPLANATIONS EXPLAIN

The third question concerns semantic and pragmatic consequence: what happens to meaning and interaction when a performance conforms to or fails a linguistic relation? This question occupies the third level in Table 1, and its answer can't be read off from the performance's grammatical-status classification. Semantic and pragmatic theory enter here in two ways. First, they help describe the content

organized by grammar. Tense, definiteness, evidential source, clause type, reference continuity, and commitment are examples rather than an exhaustive list. The range matters because a grammatical relation can organize a temporal or referential value, a clause's communicative type, or the continuity of participants across clauses; grammatical content isn't limited in advance to one semantic level. Second, semantic and pragmatic theories explain the consequences of combining those values: an attempted interpretation may conflict, remain underspecified, invite coercion, or alter the course of a conversation. The first contribution helps specify what a norm organizes; the second explains what conformity or failure does.

5.1 SEMANTIC REPAIRABILITY

Abrusán (2019, pp. 329–334, 344–350) asks a close relative of this paper's question: why can a failed interpretation feel ungrammatical in one case, semantically anomalous in another, and pragmatically infelicitous in a third? A NEGATIVE-POLARITY ITEM such as *anything*, which ordinarily requires negation or another licensing environment, is often classified as ungrammatical in **John saw anything* even though the proposed licensing condition is semantic. By contrast, *My toothbrush is pregnant* is readily understood as a selectional absurdity rather than as a syntactic failure. The contrast shows why locating a source in semantics doesn't yet predict how speakers will classify the fault.

The toothbrush side of this contrast has an older diagnosis. Coseriu (2019, p. 37) argues that most expressions starred as ungrammatical in linguistics books, such as *He puesto a cocinar el piano* 'I've put the piano on to cook', are incongruent rather than incorrect, since a hearer's reply questions the speaker's sanity rather than their Spanish. He treats the standard generative example of a meaningless but well-formed sentence as a question of congruence too, one that a poetic context can suspend (Coseriu, 2019, p. 101, n. 77).

Abrusán et al. (2021, pp. 250–251, 263, 268–270) explain an important part of that contrast through type level, locality, and semantic shift. A local conflict involving a relatively specific type can sometimes be repaired by adjusting a word's interpretation in context. The adjective in *heavy traffic*, for example, doesn't retain exactly its ordinary physical-weight interpretation. But conflicts involving high-level types such as question formation or determiner logic may leave no nearby meaning-preserving shift. Because the type system and permitted shifts are motivated independently of the eventual anomaly label, Abrusán and colleagues explain rather than merely rename a classification distinction.

That semantic explanation has a defined explanatory domain. It can explain responses where composition or interpretation supplies the trouble. But it doesn't, by itself, decide whether French article non-elision, a suppletive past form, a pure phonotactic violation, or a spelling error belongs to grammar. Those examples remain easy to understand because semantic composition has largely succeeded. The assembly-norm proposal and the repairability account overlap when grammar organizes semantic composition, but they answer different questions.

This difference also yields distinct failure conditions. If type level and shiftability fully explain why respondents classify a semantic conflict as ungrammatical rather than anomalous, an additional assembly-based explanation of that response is unnecessary. But Abrusán's resources challenge the present answer to norm constitution only if they also explain what makes the failed linguistic relation grammatical. Explaining a response and constituting the norm remain separate tasks.

This means that semantics is neither outside grammar nor identical to it. A tense construction can belong to grammar partly because it conventionally assembles a temporal value, and semantic

theory explains what that value is. If two linguistically encoded temporal instructions conflict, semantic theory may also explain the resulting anomaly. But a further premise is still needed to show whether the convention that assembled those instructions belongs to grammar, lexical semantics, or a pragmatic practice.

5.2 DISCOURSE CONSEQUENCES WITHOUT A UNITARY PUBLIC STATE

Some grammatical choices do more than contribute to propositional content (the situation an utterance depicts). They also help determine what conversational move the speaker has made and what an interlocutor is now entitled, expected, or able to do. An interrogative construction typically presents an issue for response, whereas a declarative construction ordinarily presents a claim. An evidential marker can present the speaker or someone else as the source of the information. A switch-reference marker can indicate whether the next clause continues with the same participant or shifts to another. I call these DISCOURSE CONSEQUENCES: effects on the public organization of interaction, not merely on the situation described.

Several traditions converge on this terrain from different directions. The starting distinction in Heltoft's account is plain: "there is no direct relationship between grammaticality and comprehensibility" (Heltoft, 1981, p. 95). His treatment of epistemic verbs shows how a form can remain understandable even when it fails a grammatical relation, and how the grammatical distinction can concern the speaker's positioning of a claim (Heltoft, 1981, pp. 99–104). Heltoft (2005, pp. 81–82, 92–98) distinguishes the illocutionary role of mood (the kind of communicative act performed) from the interlocutionary role of dialogic particles, which helps organize the relation between one turn and the next. Hansen and Heltoft (2011, vol. 1, 43–80, 142–149) and Jakobsen and Heltoft (2012, pp. 77–84, 104–106) develop the connection between paradigmatic organization and discourse function. Interactional research starts from the organization of conversation and treats grammar as a resource for constructing sequences of action and locating and repairing trouble (Fox et al., 1996, pp. 185–190, 231–237; Muntigl and Ventola, 2010, pp. 99–103, 123–124; Dingemanse et al., 2014, pp. 5–10).

These traditions support the claim that grammatical organization can have public consequences. They don't support the converse claim that anything with a public consequence is grammatical. Ameka (1992, pp. 101–108) analyzes interjections as a distinct class of conventional expressions with their own semantic and pragmatic properties. An item such as *oh* can constitute an utterance and function as a discourse marker, but that discourse function alone doesn't show that it participates in a grammatical paradigm. Conversely, a grammatical distinction can make little difference in a particular performance. In *These books are useful*, plurality is already expressed by *these* and *books*, so the agreement realized by *are* adds little locally. But the agreement paradigm may matter elsewhere. This token illustrates how a grammatical contrast can be locally redundant without settling what the paradigm does in other environments. Discourse consequence and grammatical status have to be identified independently.

Representing all discourse consequences as movement along one scale, as though every grammatical choice simply changed more or less of a single public information store, would also be misleading. Bary (2025, pp. 505–506, 508–511, 515–519, 523–526) argues that at least three things need to be separated: what interlocutors jointly treat as settled, which participant is publicly committed to a proposition, and what institutional or performative change an utterance itself brings about. Simons (2025, pp. 179–183, 201–209) presses the separation further. Information can be available and appropriate for interpretation without being mutually accepted as common ground, and the informa-

tion used to interpret a speech act needn't be identical to the information that the act changes.

A grammatical choice can have several potentially independent discourse effects. A DISCOURSE-CONSEQUENCE PROFILE is the analyst's estimate of those effects, not an additional property that constitutes grammatical status. Rather than assigning a paradigm one number, the profile records evidence bearing on:

- MOVE TYPE: whether the utterance functions as an assertion, question, request, or some other move.
- COMMITMENT HOLDER OR SOURCE: whether the speaker, another person, or no fully committed source is presented as responsible for the information.
- PARTICIPANT OR REFERENT CONTINUITY: whether subsequent material is interpreted as continuing with the same person or shifting to another.
- RESPONSE RELEVANCE: which kinds of reply the utterance makes conditionally appropriate.

A paradigm may have a strong effect on one dimension and almost none on another. The multidimensional discourse-consequence profile assumes neither a unitary public state nor universal weights among these dimensions.

The discourse-consequence profile applies only to a grammatical choice already identified on independent grounds. It isn't part of the definition of grammar. Clause type, evidential anchoring, and switch-reference are plausible high-consequence examples because changing their values can alter the move, source, or participant carried forward. Ordinary allomorphy is usually a low-consequence example. Replacing *went* with **goed* violates a realization relation but ordinarily leaves the intended past value and conversational move intact. Interjections make the converse point: a resource can reshape uptake without thereby forming part of grammatical assembly.

This separation permits a more specific repair prediction. Consider an independently identified switch-reference paradigm whose values distinguish continuation by the same subject from continuation by a different subject. Now compare two failures. In the first, a same-subject value occurs in a clause chain whose clauses specify different subjects. The performance supplies incompatible grammatical instructions: one part indicates continuity, while another indicates a change of participant. A hearer who detects the conflict may need to clarify who performs the second action. In the second failure, the intended different-subject value remains recoverable but its exponent has an excluded phonological realization. The participant shift is already clear, so correcting the form can leave the interpretation and discourse organization unchanged.

The prediction isn't that every value conflict provokes clarification or that every realization failure receives an overt correction. Speakers can accommodate, ignore, mishear, or respond to some other aspect of the utterance. The prediction concerns the LOCUS OF REPAIR: what a response attempts to settle. Internal value incompatibilities should more often direct repair toward force, commitment, participant role, or reference. Value-preserving realization failures should more often direct repair toward form while preserving the intended discourse effect. Across independently identified paradigms, this difference should grow with the independently estimated discourse effects. The hypothesis concerns a consequence of grammatical status: it predicts what different grammatical failures may do rather than deciding what counts as grammatical.

The relevant information-theoretic hypothesis is that bounded alternatives create redundancy and can make an intended value recoverable even when its exponent is malformed. The hypothesis belongs at the consequence level, not the definition of grammar. Suppose a paradigm contains only

same-subject and different-subject values. Even when the exponent is malformed, the surrounding clause chain and the limited competitor set may make the intended value recoverable. Shannon’s framework begins with a message selected from a set of possible messages and uses entropy and redundancy to characterize uncertainty in that set (Shannon, 1948, pp. 379, 392–399). Entropy measures uncertainty within a distribution; conditional entropy and mutual information measure remaining uncertainty and its reduction; and divergence measures the difference between distributions (Cover & Thomas, 2006, pp. 13–22). Applying these measures to recoverability or repair is the hypothesis proposed here, not a result established by the information-theory sources.

But these measures apply only after linguistic analysis has identified the alternatives and their conventional functions. An information-theoretic calculation can quantify how strongly same-subject and different-subject values constrain a response space. It can’t discover that these are the relevant alternatives, determine whether they form a grammatical paradigm, establish that a performance fails a form–value relation, or explain why that failure is accountable within a community. The linguistic codebook is an input to the calculation, not its output.

6 DIFFICULT CASES AS TESTS OF THE ONTOLOGY

The difficult cases bring together the norm-individuation procedure in Section 3.2, the token-failure distinctions in Section 4, and the semantic and discourse explanations in Section 5. The first two locate the candidate norm and fault; the third helps explain a neighbouring analysis or a downstream consequence. Together, they test whether the distinctions in Table 2 can be assigned from the organization of the relation before a respondent’s label is known. Table 5 states the relevant contrasts.

Case	Candidate relation	Neighboring analysis	What would decide
<i>*le hiver</i>	conditioned realization of the definite-article construction	general phonological form formation or graphic convention	construction specificity, medium, lexical grouping, and elision distribution
<i>*goed</i>	realization of past value in an inflectional choice	lexeme-specific word form	productivity of the tense construction and item-specific pre-emption
<i>*depend of</i>	head-specific relation in complement and valence organization	lexical collocation	argument role, phrasal category, head restriction, and substitution pattern
Register or honorific mismatch	grammaticalized form–social-value choice or licensed social-indexical sign	situational deployment of an already licensed value	recurrence, constructional domain, alternative set, and whether assembly succeeds
Misspelling	graphic representation of a linguistic expression	grammatical realization in a writing-specific construction	whether the graphic contrast represents a sign or realizes a constructional value
Selectional anomaly	constructional compatibility relation	lexical-semantic or world-knowledge conflict	conventional locality, productivity, type level, and semantic repairability

Table 5: Difficult cases. The final column identifies evidence to be fixed independently of prior grammaticality verdicts and repairs.

6.1 FRENCH ARTICLE REALIZATION AND PURE PHONOTACTICS

The French case provides a test of the distinction between form formation and grammatical realization. Boersma (2007, pp. 1990–1991, 1994) reports that the final vowel of singular *le* or *la* elides

phrase-internally before a vowel-initial noun, remains before a consonant-initial noun, and also remains before an H ASPIRÉ noun. The prevocalic elision is obligatory in the described variety. These distributions provide positive evidence rather than a borrowed grammar label. Table 6 applies the three-stage analysis from Section 3.2 through the point at which its response prediction can be frozen. It first declares the repertoire and the proposed relata, then records the distributional evidence for the relation, and finally states what would count against either the grammatical analysis or its response prediction. The table doesn't report a judgment study. Its purpose is to show what an analyst would have to establish before asking anyone whether the problem sounds grammatical or phonological.

Component	French elision reconstruction
Scope	contemporary French as described by Boersma, with speech primary and graphic realization analyzed separately
Relata and site	singular definite article values and their realizations before a vowel-initial or H MUET noun
Independent evidence	the <i>le/la/l'</i> opposition, preservation of definiteness and gender–number, phrase-internal distribution, and the contrasts with consonant-initial and H ASPIRÉ nouns
Assembly analysis	conditioned realization of a selected article value
Neighbouring analysis	general hiatus avoidance, phonotactic form formation, or graphic convention
Evidence against the grammatical analysis	outcome-blind distribution supports only a general phonological-form relation and no value-conditioned realization relation embedded in the relevant constructional class
Frozen prediction	speakers more often identify article formation as the problem than they do for matched pure phonotactic or graphic failures
Evidence against the prediction	held-out responses systematically target phonology rather than article realization despite independent support for the assembly relation

Table 6: A qualitative assembly profile frozen before response outcomes. This isn't a completed held-out test.

The intended definite, masculine, singular value remains recoverable in **le hiver*. The analysis is neutral between deriving *l'* through vowel deletion and treating it as an allomorph. What matters is whether the selected article value is conventionally coupled to a realization conditioned by this constructional environment. A general preference against adjacent vowels wouldn't establish that claim. The contrasts among *le*, *la*, and *l'*, their association with article values, and their distribution across noun classes are what make a grammatical analysis possible.

Coseriu (2019, pp. 89–90) classifies two neighbouring cases by the same criterion. He reports that for some Spanish speakers *le* for plural *les* is no longer a matter of phonetics but of morphology: *le* has become a number-neutral dative, with number marked elsewhere, and so a new norm for those speakers. He also reports that the [z] in *vous êtes Italiens*, absent from singular *vous êtes Italien*, only looks like a liaison norm, and he classifies it as a new grammatical norm realizing plural (Coseriu, 2019, p. 90, n. 67). In each case the classification turns on whether the alternation is coupled to a constructional value, which is the question asked of *l'* here.

The two failure conditions belong to different levels. If outcome-blind distributional evidence supports only a general phonotactic relation, the constitutive grammatical analysis loses. If the assembly relation remains independently supported but respondents target phonology, the attribution prediction loses or needs qualification. Evidence for both relations warrants a multiple-relation analysis only when each relation is independently supported.

6.2 INFLECTION, COMPLEMENTATION, AND LEXICAL KNOWLEDGE

Huddleston and Pullum (2002, pp. 1596–1598, 1607) describe *-ed* as the productive regular preterite suffix and *went* as the suppletive preterite of *go*. On the analysis adopted here, **goed* conforms

to the productive past-tense schema with respect to one relation: past is realized by *-ed*. A more specific, lexeme-indexed relation realizes GO.PAST as *went* and pre-empts the general realization for this lexeme in the scoped repertoire. The form preserves past and satisfies the productive schema while failing the more specific realization relation. The two-relation analysis is supported independently by the productive schema and the stable lexeme-specific opposition. The exponent isn't intrinsically excluded; it's excluded for this lexeme.

Coseriu (2019, p. 94) states the general condition. A new formation is correct if it answers an expressive need, accords with the system, and opposes no established norm. Spanish *volvimiento*, formed like the existing *revolvimiento*, is incorrect when it means no more than *vuelta* 'return, turn', because the norm already supplies that word; used for a content *vuelta* doesn't express, it's a correct innovation. **Goed* has the same structure. The productive schema licenses the formation, and the lexeme-specific norm pre-empts it.

**Depend of* falls under the dependencies developed in Section 3.2. Huddleston and Pullum (2002, p. 220) describe the preposition in *depend on the cost* as specified by the verb and the PP as licensed as its complement. A complement construction introduces an argument relation; that relation constrains a phrasal category; and the particular head restricts the preposition. The more schematic dependencies independently contribute to grammatical assembly. The present evidence doesn't settle whether the final *depend-on* restriction is lexically indexed licensing or collocation. Mixed attribution is informative only when compared with those independently specified dependencies and their stated indeterminacy.

The lexicon more generally contains conventional form–meaning pairings. Choosing an ill-fitting but licensed word normally preserves both the word's identity and the larger construction. Calling a downpour *strong rain*, for example, doesn't by itself show that English adjective–noun modification has failed. Distribution and substitution evidence would still have to establish that the relevant repertoire favours *heavy rain* as the collocation before this case could support that analysis.

Selectional restrictions and valence frames are harder because lexical content can constrain how a construction is assembled. Abrusán's type and shift diagnostics help determine whether a semantic conflict is doing the work; constructional recurrence and substitution show whether a conventional assembly relation is also present. This evidence bears directly on grammaticality. If a head-specific restriction helps realize an independently supported complement or valence construction, its failure is grammatical because it concerns that assembly relation. If the restriction amounts only to an association between stored lexical items, the failure is lexical. For *depend on*, the argument-role and PP-category dependencies have clearer constructional support than the final choice of *on*. On the evidence considered here, that item-specific relation remains indeterminate between lexically indexed grammatical licensing and collocation.

6.3 DEPLOYMENT, REPRESENTATION, AND GRAMMATICALIZATION

Register, accent, and politeness marking, as in Japanese polite/plain-style verb suffixation, can be highly systematic and socially consequential (Agha, 2007, pp. 80–82, 301–340; Eckert, 2012, pp. 87–88, 94–99; Cook, 2008, pp. 45–64; Ide, 2005, pp. 50–53). A mismatch may preserve the form's conventional social value perfectly and fail only because that value is unsuitable for the occasion. In that case, assembly has succeeded and deployment is the fault. An honorific or style contrast participates in grammatical assembly when it functions within a repertoire as a recurrent constructional choice with a domain, alternatives, and conditioned selection. The account doesn't exclude pragmatic or

social content from grammar in advance.

Orthography normally maps graphic forms to linguistic expressions. Consider a writer who intends *They're leaving now* but writes **Their leaving now*. The spellings *their* and *they're* distinguish a possessive form from the contraction of *they are*, even though they're homophonous for many speakers. A reader may recover the intended clause immediately. On a purely representational analysis, the writer has selected the wrong graphic form for an otherwise recoverable linguistic expression; the fault is orthographic. But the spelling also makes a different syntactic analysis available: *their leaving* can begin a gerund-participial clause with a genitive subject (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1189–1193), so the written token may contain a secondary constructional conflict. As a result, the analysis should identify the graphic mapping and the clause structure separately rather than infer one fault type from the fact that the sentence is written. More generally, a graphic contrast is grammatical when it realizes a constructional value, but merely orthographic when it represents an expression already identified. The medium doesn't determine the norm type; the relation's contribution to expression formation does.

The boundaries just illustrated can also change over time. Diachronic change can recruit lexical material into grammatical functions and integrate it into constructional or paradigmatic organization (Hopper and Traugott, 2003, pp. 1–3, 71–98, 159–165; Lehmann, 2015, pp. 129–152; Jakobsen and Heltoft, 2012, pp. 77–84, 104–106). Developments involving discourse markers also recruit material into discourse-organizing functions, though their status as grammaticalization or pragmaticalization remains disputed (Waltereit, 2011, pp. 413–423; Degand and Evers-Vermeul, 2015, pp. 59–65, 80–84). Historical origin doesn't fix present status. The relevant question is how the relation functions in the scoped repertoire now.

6.4 A DISCOURSE-CONSEQUENCE APPLICATION

Section 5.2 predicted different repair loci for internal value conflicts and value-preserving realization failures. Amele switch-reference provides a source-grounded template for that comparison. Roberts (1987, pp. 236, 273, 293–295, 363) describes a sequential paradigm contrasting same-subject (SS) and different-subject (DS) linkage on medial verbs, with person–number marking and vowel harmony in the DS form. Example 1 is Roberts's attested different-subject clause chain.

- (1) *Hina ho-co-m sab je-i-a.*
 2SG come-DS-2SG food eat-3SG-TOD.PST
 'You came and he ate the food.'

The medial verb *ho-co-m* marks the subject of “come” as second-person singular and signals that the next clause has a different subject. The final verb *je-i-a* supplies the third-person subject and today's-past tense. Thus the DS form and the person marking converge on a change of participant; the translation alone isn't being used to infer the paradigm. Table 7 starts from this attested conforming form and gives two deliberately constructed candidates that would have to be validated before use in a study.

The internal-conflict candidate constitutes a grammatical failure only if the subject information is supplied by the clause chain and the SS value conflicts with it. A speaker who merely intends a different continuation after producing a well-formed SS chain has made a message-selection error instead. The realization condition preserves DS but violates the harmony relation described for its form.

Condition	Amele form	Analysis
Attested conforming form	<i>Hina ho-co-m sab je-i-a</i>	‘You came and he ate the food’ (DS)
Constructed internal-conflict candidate	<i>Hina h-u-me-g sab je-i-a</i>	licensed 2sg SS form conflicts with the distinct subject supplied by the following clause
Constructed realization-failure candidate	<i>Hina ho-ce-m sab je-i-a</i>	DS and 2sg material are retained, but the DS vowel is disharmonic after <i>ho-</i>

Table 7: A schematic Amele switch-reference comparison. The two candidate sequences are constructed from Roberts’s paradigm and haven’t been validated as judgments in the intended clause-chain context.

The attested paradigm establishes the formal contrast, but the published grammar doesn’t print either constructed candidate or the exact disharmonic stimulus. The comparison is a source-grounded template that requires validation, not an empirical result.

If the internal conflict is established, the two failures yield different discourse predictions. An SS/DS conflict can unsettle reference continuity; a disharmonic realization need not. Whether participants direct repair to reference or form remains a separate causal and empirical question. The ontology permits this cross-level inference; it isn’t evidence used to define the switch-reference relation as grammatical.

The methodological question is how to test that prediction without using repair behaviour to identify the paradigm or fault in the first place. Section 7 states the required evidential order.

7 METHODOLOGICAL CONSEQUENCES AND FAILURE CONDITIONS

Many studies begin with a judgment (a low rating, an asterisk, or a correction) and then ask what caused it. This section returns to the three response and evidence questions distinguished in Section 2: target attribution, response causation, and epistemic justification. Judgment evidence is useful, but by itself it bundles three of the questions distinguished above. The response has a target, such as article formation or pronunciation; it has causes, such as linguistic knowledge, processing, schooling, or stigma; and it gives the analyst fallible evidence about the norm and the token. If an analyst uses the same response both to infer the norm and to confirm that speakers identify it, the argument is circular. The account requires a different evidential order.

The following steps order the evidence; they aren’t procedural counterparts of the six explanatory questions. A worked investigation would proceed in six steps. First, declare the relevant community, activity, medium, and period. That scope can be refined from outcome-blind evidence about interaction, exposure, production, and interpretation.

Second, identify the proposed relation. State the constructional units, exponents, values, and constructional site, using substitution, omission, productivity, contrast organization, and distribution rather than prior grammaticality verdicts.

Third, state the closest alternative analysis. For French elision, the relevant rivals are a general phonotactic relation and a graphic convention. The analysis has to say what outcome-blind evidence

would favour each account.

Fourth, freeze the analysis before examining the target judgments or repairs. This includes the repertoire, the candidate relation, the uncertainty in its assembly profile, and the conditions that would defeat it.

Fifth, collect response evidence from new tokens or a disjoint corpus partition. Open descriptions and spontaneous corrections should precede forced choices among “grammar”, “wording”, “style”, and related labels.

Finally, explain the responses. Code what each response targets separately from what probably caused it. Schoolroom terminology, processing difficulty, stigma, and task demands can shape a response without determining the token’s grammatical status.

The order doesn’t make judgments irrelevant. It makes clear what they can show. A spontaneous replacement of *le* with *l’* may indicate that a respondent has located the trouble in article realization. An explanation such as “two vowels can’t occur together” may instead target phonology. Neither response, by itself, decides which worldly relation is present. That question was addressed in the outcome-blind stages; the response provides evidence about whether the respondent identifies the proposed relation and how they describe it. A construction-directed response isn’t automatically grammar-directed because lexical constructions are part of the distinction at issue. Mixed and unresolved responses remain visible.

The comparison set has to challenge the constitutive distinction rather than merely contrast easy grammatical examples with unrelated controls. It should include strict paradigms, productive constructions, value-preserving realization failures, item-specific licensing dependencies, pure phonotactic and orthographic departures, inapposite but licensed lexical choices, social-indexical mismatches, and violations of social acts. The items should remain interpretable, since the question is why recoverable performances receive different fault classifications. If the assembly analysis is adjusted after the responses are known, the test has collapsed back into an account of labeling.

Rival explanations operate at different levels. Semantic reparability may explain classifications where composition fails. Boye and Harder’s discursive secondary status may better identify grammatical norms. Frequency, surprisal, perceptual salience, and processing can cause low ratings or rapid correction. Schooling, stigma, participant role, the respondent’s presumption about the producer’s competence (Coseriu, 2019, pp. 98–99), and institutional authority can cause grammar-directed labels or person-directed sanction, so producer identity should be matched across items. Activity, medium, register, community, and period define the population of the grammatical-status claim rather than serving as a bag of statistical controls. A good design restricts or matches these causes where possible and states which remaining comparison is identified.

Two held-out predictions follow, together with a descriptive expectation about layered and changing relations. First, relations independently identified as grammatical assembly norms should more consistently prompt speakers to identify expression formation as the problem than matched lexical, phonotactic, representational, deployment, and social-act faults. Explicit grammar labels should correlate with that more specific fault attribution, but the correlation is a related response-level expectation and may be weakened by schooling or local metalinguistic practice.

The descriptive expectation is that performances with independently supported relations of different types, and relations changing over time, produce different or changing classifications among grammar, lexicon, phonology, and style. The second held-out prediction concerns paradigms that

independently support both error types: a stronger discourse-consequence profile should increase the difference in discourse-directed repair between internal value conflicts and value-preserving realization failures.

These predictions are evidential consequences, not definitions. The constitutive account fails if its functional criteria can't distinguish phonotactics, lexical identity, representation, deployment, and mixed constructional cases without relying on the responses to be explained. Its empirical reach fails if independently estimated assembly organization adds no stable held-out expectation about fault attribution or classification change beyond semantic reparability, discursive secondary status, processing, schooling, and sanction. The discourse application fails if the independently estimated consequence profile doesn't predict the repair-locus difference in an identifying comparison.

Some outcomes are inconclusive rather than favourable or fatal. A corpus of corrections contains only occasions on which someone corrected, so it can't by itself estimate how a community classifies all comparable tokens. Naturally occurring internal value conflicts and realization failures may also be too sparse or uneven for the repair comparison. Such data can test search procedures, coding, and candidate analyses without being promoted into a confirmatory result. The account earns support only from comparisons whose norm evidence and outcome evidence are separable in practice.

8 CONCLUSION

Why does one interpretable deviation count as ungrammatical while another does not? My answer can now be stated in the order of its six questions.

First, as Section 3.1 argued, coordinated linguistic practice supplies a thin standard of correctness within a scoped repertoire. This answers the question of **NORM CONSTITUTION**. The standard belongs to grammar when it relates independently supported constructional units, exponents, positions, or values in the recurrent assembly of constructions. Lexical conventions, phonotactics, orthography, and usage norms are equally conventional, but they ordinarily establish sign identity, constrain phonological form, represent an expression, or govern its deployment.

Second, Section 4's question of **TOKEN APPLICATION** asks whether a performance conforms to the assembly standard. A performance can be defective with respect to one relation while remaining recognizable as an attempted instance because other relations are preserved. **Le hiver*, for example, preserves definiteness, number, gender, and reference while failing the proposed article-realization relation. Recoverability doesn't erase the fault, and failure of one relation doesn't prevent the performance from being identified through the relations it preserves.

Third, Section 5 showed why the **SEMANTIC OR PRAGMATIC CONSEQUENCE** of a grammatical fault requires its own explanation. A failure may block composition, invite a semantic repair, leave the proposition intact, or unsettle move type, commitment, participant continuity, or response relevance. Abrusán's account explains an important subset of anomaly classifications, and discourse theory explains why some grammatical values reorganize interaction. Neither type of explanation alone determines whether the failed relation belongs to grammar.

Fourth, the **TARGET ATTRIBUTION** tested by the procedure in Section 7 concerns whether a respondent treats the trouble as article formation, pronunciation, spelling, wording, style, or conduct. That attribution may be mistaken.

Fifth, **RESPONSE CAUSATION** asks why the respondent reacted. Processing difficulty, frequency, perceptual salience, schooling, stigma, participant role, and institutional authority can produce rejec-

tion or correction without determining grammatical status. They can also prevent a speaker from noticing a genuine grammatical fault.

Finally, EPISTEMIC JUSTIFICATION requires the proposed relation, its repertoire, and its closest rival to be individuated from outcome-blind production, interpretation, substitution, omission, and distribution before held-out judgments and repairs test whether speakers track it.

These separations yield the two tests announced in the introduction. Independently identified assembly faults should attract more consistent formation-directed attribution than matched neighbouring faults. Among grammatical paradigms, stronger discourse consequences should increase the difference between discourse-directed repair of value conflicts and form-directed repair of value-preserving realization failures.

Norm types aren't assigned by expressive substance: phonological material can realize grammar, pragmatic values can enter paradigms, and item-specific knowledge can participate in constructional dependencies. Multiple-relation analysis is justified only when each proposed relation recurs or contrasts independently and predicts further cases; otherwise, the unit of analysis remains indeterminate.

The motivating French case has a deliberately conditional purpose. **Le hiver* counts as a grammatical-form error only if the conditioned realization of the article, rather than pure phonotactics or graphic convention, is what fails in the scoped repertoire. The theory can be wrong about that case without redefining grammar to save it. More generally, if the assembly criterion can't distinguish the difficult cases without recycling their labels, the constitutive answer fails and the narrower theory of metalinguistic attribution is all that remains.

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